

Although college may leave you with significant debt, the substantial increase in salary will make up for it in the long run. This puts young people in a difficult situation: on the one hand, they are told about the horrors of student debt; on the other hand, they are told that a college degree is one of the best paths to making more money.

The goal of this chapter is to help you achieve your educational goals at the lowest financial cost. With this in mind, I urge young students to think this decision through carefully. You are already at a disadvantage because you are being asked to make one of the biggest financial decisions of your life when some of you are not even old enough to vote. This chapter is going to help you understand how your educational choices today will impact your financial reality tomorrow.

Choose the Right School

I do not share these statistics and resources only to give you anxiety and terrify you about your future; I share them so you can go into college and adult life with your eyes wide open. Because college can be outrageously expensive, you need to be doing everything you can to reduce the costs and help out your future self.

One of the biggest mistakes I see high school students make is choosing their dream school without examining the financial cost of this decision. Then, once they are accepted to their dream school, there is nothing that is going to stop them from enrolling. Unfortunately, dream schools are often expensive and do not provide a value equal to their costs. Choosing the “best” school you are accepted to may not be the best decision for your future; you need to factor in the cost.